

TRU suspends professor at centre of academic freedom debate, citing Facebook post

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James Peters

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KAMLOOPS — A TRU professor at the centre of a dispute with the school over academic freedom says the school has suspended him for one year.

Dr. Derek Pyne says TRU's human resources department informed him of the suspension Thursday (July 16).

According to Pyne, the suspension is in response to a post he made on Facebook in June. The post shared a statement from the faculty association of Ontario's Brock University (BUFA) about academic freedom. In lauding BUFA's stand, Pyne contrasted it with that of TRU and his own faculty association, TRUFA. He then tagged specific members of TRUFA's leadership, predicting they would go "running" to Larry Phillips, TRU's executive director of human resources.

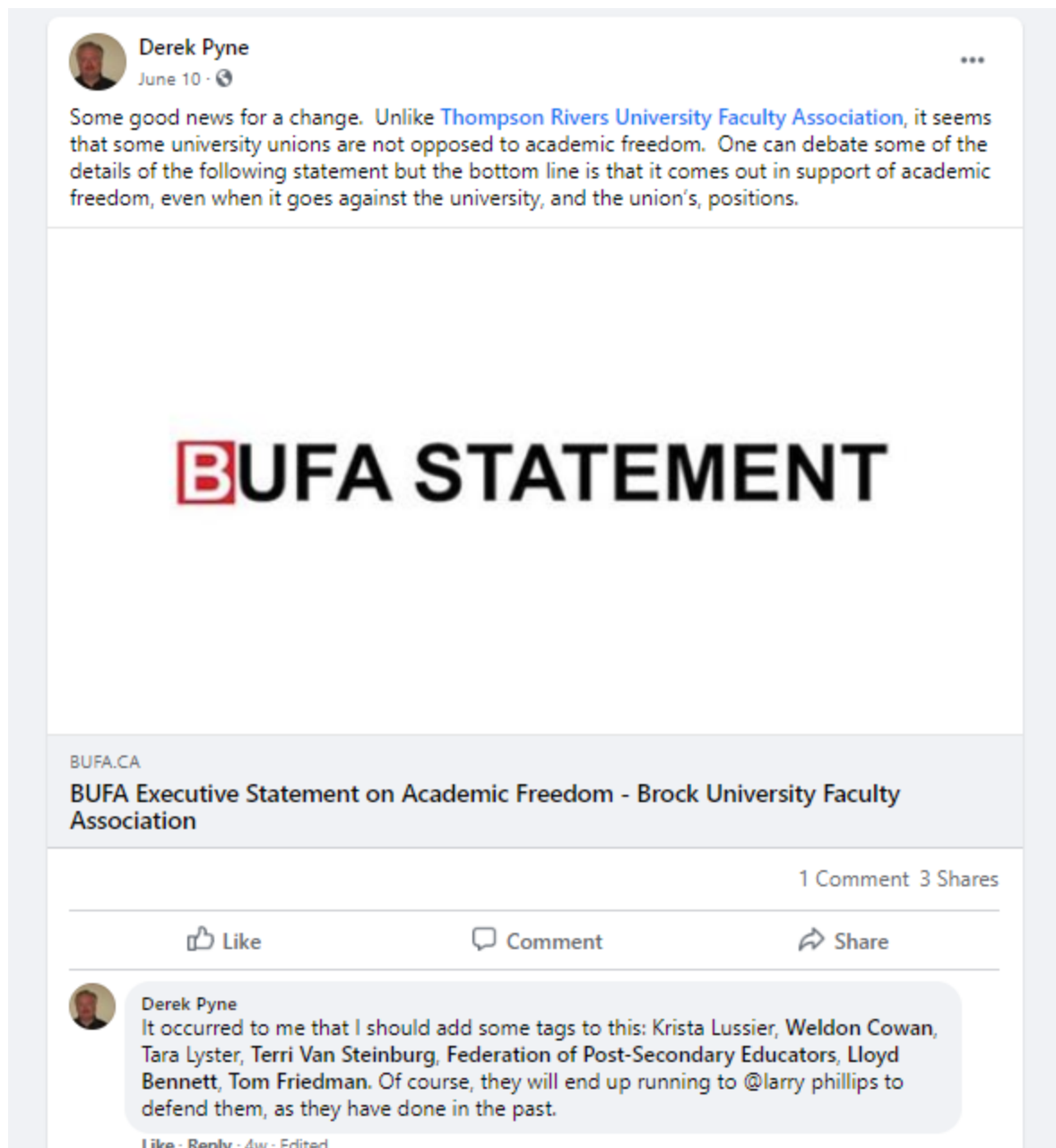


Image Credit: Facebook / Derek Pyne

Pyne tells *CFJC Today* TRU sent him a letter about the Facebook post last week. He subsequently met with human resources officials Thursday, who cited 'progressive discipline' in suspending him for one year.

In a statement, TRU's director of executive and government relations, Darshan Lindsay, would not confirm specifics about disciplinary action involving Pyne.

However, Lindsay said, “we want to be clear that matters involving Dr. Pyne are not about the exercise of academic freedom.”

Lindsay says TRU supports the exercise of academic freedom, including “the ability to conduct independent research, freely communicate knowledge and the results of research and scholarship, and respectfully debate differences.”

Lindsay goes on to say employment matters can be grieved through TRUFA and complaints can be filed through the B.C. Labour Relations Board (BCLRB).

As TRUFA members filed the complaint against Pyne’s social media post, Pyne says he doubts TRUFA will carry out a grievance on his behalf.

As for the BCLRB, [a previous complaint filed by Pyne against TRU](#) over academic freedom concerns was dismissed one year ago to the day. Pyne appealed the decision, saying TRUFA failed to properly represent him, [but the appeal was denied](#).

Pyne has battled with TRU previously in relation to his research on colleagues’ work appearing in so-called predatory academic publications. His work appeared in the *Journal of Scholarly Publishing* and was covered in the *New York Times*. TRU suspended him in 2018, prompting an investigation and [scathing report from the Canadian Association of University Teachers](#). At that time again, TRU said Pyne’s academic freedom was protected at the university.

CFJC Today requested comment from TRUFA President Monica Sanchez-Flores, but she declined, citing the confidentiality of its members, including Pyne.

by James Peters